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The Crucible
Command of the Battalion

Sometime in February 1981, I reached Tezu to take over as the CO of 9 Maratha LI. The brigade commander, Brigadier Harwant Singh, warmly received me and asked my predecessor, Lieutenant Colonel Tony Fernandes, to take me to our operational area and brief me. Before we went on our reconnaissance, the brigade commander was kind enough to promote me and graciously put the epaulettes of a lieutenant colonel on my shoulders. Then off we went to Hayuliang. This involved a road journey of over 200 kilometres over a bumpy and treacherous mountainous road snaking up along the Lohit valley. Lieutenant Colonel Fernandes was driving rather fast and at times a bit rash, as he wanted to come back the same day. I advised him to take it easy, but to no avail. Unfortunately, we met with an accident due to brake failure and consequent loss of control. The jonga (an army SUV) crashed into the hillside and took a side roll and overturned with all four wheels looking up at the skies. Something like the stunts one sees in the movies, only much better, because it wasn't rehearsed! One more roll would have meant the end for all of us, as beyond the edge of the road was a sheer drop of about 1000 feet into the turquoise-blue Lohit river.

It was a miraculous escape. All of us, with the exception of Lieutenant Colonel Fernandes, got away with a few cuts, bruises and blunt injuries. Sadly, Tony's right hand was crushed between the superstructure and the steering. He needed to be evacuated to the hospital at Guwahati urgently. No briefing or 'handing over' could